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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

Velocity, Complexity, Humanity: Rethinking Marketing in the AI Era

Date & time: Oct. 14, 1:35-2:05 PM EST
Track: Featured Main Stage



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Session Description

AI can help marketers move faster, but turning that speed into meaningful growth requires rethinking how teams work. In this session, Izabelle Macedo, Managing Director, Americas, Google Cloud Marketing, explores how organizations can move beyond individual experimentation and efficiency gains to build shared capabilities, navigate marketing's growing complexity, and strengthen human judgment.

Drawing on Google's approach to AI adoption, she examines why organizational context matters, how teams can share and scale what they learn, and where human creativity and decision-making remain essential. Attendees will leave with a clearer perspective on measuring value, supporting their teams, and using AI to do work that neither people nor technology could accomplish alone.

Key Quote

> *"Don't put AI to work on something that you could have already done yourself, but put AI to work on something that neither of you could have done alone."*
> **- Izabelle Macedo**

Session Summary

Izabelle Macedo, Managing Director, Americas, Google Cloud Marketing, argued that AI in marketing is somewhere beyond the end of the beginning: even if development stopped tomorrow, today's tools could already do remarkable things. The challenge, she said, is speed. PCs took more than 20 years to reach mass adoption and the internet about a decade, while AI reached the main stage in under four years and lives inside devices we already use. When capabilities advance faster than teams can form habits, the risk of distraction is high, and it is better to go slowly in the right direction than fast in the wrong one.

Macedo proposed thinking of AI not as a tool but as an environment: it is connected to our docs, email, search and files, so its effects are subtle and harder to notice. A healthy environment depends on context, and much of what defines an organization lives outside formal documents, in culture, unsent drafts and the way people work. Teaching teams to capture and transfer that context is less exciting than handing them new tools but far more valuable. She warned against the “slop grenade,” long AI-generated documents someone lobs at colleagues, because they pollute the inputs that shape future outputs, and noted that Google Cloud weighs efficiency as heavily as effectiveness, matching the right model to the job.

On complexity, she traced four eras of marketing: broadcast, digital, social and now algorithmic. Each new era layered on top of the last rather than replacing it, and each runs on different fundamentals, leaving marketers to reconcile brand and conversion, niche and scale, and stakeholders with conflicting demands. Rather than seeing AI as making this worse, she called it the right technology for the moment, since decades of playbooks and performance data can be fed to AI to connect the dots.

The final theme was humanity. Identifying what can be handed to AI also reveals what is truly ours: judgment, experience, creativity, curiosity and connection. She described letting AI do “the maths” while people do “the magic,” and rejected a substitution mindset of placing agents into org charts as a race to the bottom. Examples included her Brazil team using AI to schedule 300 booth-staffing invitations for a 5,000-person Google Cloud Summit, and a Media Lab agent for legal and compliance review shared across marketing, with edge cases routed to humans.

Macedo closed with guidance for leaders: pick metrics that prioritize adaptation over raw adoption, reward teams for sharing and showing their work, treat complexity as a feature, and focus on long-term growth rather than marginal cost savings. AI should support decisions, not make them, and the real change ahead is cultural rather than technological.

Key Takeaways

- **Go slow in the right direction.** Capabilities alone do not equal progress, so prioritize adaptation and habit-building over chasing the speed of new releases.
- **Treat AI as an environment.** Because AI is now embedded in docs, email and search, its effects are subtle and indirect, which calls for thinking about influence and prioritization rather than one-off tool use.
- **Context is the biggest lever.** Teaching teams to capture and share organizational context with AI is more valuable than giving them the latest tools, and avoiding “slop grenade” keeps future outputs from being polluted.

- **Embrace complexity as a feature.** Marketing's layered broadcast, digital, social and algorithmic eras are complex, but AI can analyze decades of playbooks and performance data to connect the dots.
- **Let AI do the maths, people do the magic.** Use AI for analysis and data processing while protecting human judgment, creativity and emotional connection, and avoid a substitution mindset.
- **Make sharing the norm.** Move from personal AI discovery to team-wide adoption by building agents once, sharing them across the organization, and rewarding people for showing their work.